

2026 RENTING GUIDE

Your Greater Vancouver Renter's Guide

Search smarter. Apply stronger. Move in with confidence.

Hi, I'm Devin.

I'm a Leasing Agent helping renters find homes throughout Greater Vancouver. I've spent more than 28 years in the Tri-Cities and have worked with landlords and property managers, so I understand what they look for in a clean, complete application and what renters should verify before signing.

THE GOAL

Be prepared, move quickly when the right home appears, and understand the full cost and terms before committing.



- 1 SEARCH SMART**
Budget for rent plus utilities, parking, insurance and commuting.
- 2 APPLY READY**
Keep ID, income documents, references and a short renter profile ready.
- 3 MOVE IN RIGHT**
Review the lease and document condition before the first box arrives.

QUICK START CHECKLIST



Set a full monthly budget:
rent + utilities + parking +
insurance + internet



Prepare ID, income
documents and landlord/
employer references



Choose 2-3 target areas
and know your commute
limits



Be ready to apply quickly
when the right home
appears

01 / FIND THE RIGHT FIT

Build the real monthly budget

Rent is only one line on the spreadsheet. Sadly, spreadsheets have more lines.

COMMON RENTAL TYPES

CONDO

Modern amenities and great locations. Confirm strata bylaws, move-in fees, parking and what utilities are included.

BASEMENT SUITE

Often more affordable and quiet. Confirm sound transfer, private access, laundry and whether utilities are shared.

TOWNHOME

More space and multiple levels. Ask about strata rules, visitor parking, yard care and utility setup.

DETACHED PROPERTY

Most privacy and space. Confirm yard care, garbage, heat source and who handles maintenance.

MONTHLY COST CHECK

Rent

- + Hydro / heat
- + Internet
- + Parking / storage
- + Laundry
- + Tenant insurance
- + Commuting
- + Move-in fee / elevator booking (if applicable)

HYDRO PLANNING - USEFUL BENCHMARK

BC Hydro reports average apartment use of about 198 kWh/month with non-electric heat and 365 kWh/month with electric heat.

At the current flat rate, that works out to roughly \$33 or \$54 per month before tax and adjustments.

Exact costs vary based on your usage, building and rate plan. Per-square-foot utility estimates are usually misleading.

GREATER VANCOUVER AREA SNAPSHOT

Vancouver

Transit-rich, walkable and diverse neighbourhoods, with a mix of older and newer rentals.

Burnaby + New West

Great value, excellent SkyTrain access and many condo options.

Tri-Cities

Port Moody, Coquitlam and Port Coquitlam offer parks, SkyTrain (WCE), and a mix of condos, townhomes and suites.

North Shore

Outdoor access, family-friendly neighbourhoods and a relaxed lifestyle; bridge commute required.

Richmond

Canada Line, shopping and airport access, with many condo communities.

Surrey + Langley

More space and newer rentals, with a wider range of prices and longer commute times for some.

QUESTIONS TO ASK EARLY

- 1 Which utilities are included?
- 2 Any parking, storage or move-in fees?
- 3 Are there strata, pet or smoking rules?
- 4 How is laundry handled?

Make your application easy to approve

Complete, clear and verifiable beats a frantic pile of screenshots.

YOUR APPLICATION PACKAGE

1

PHOTO ID

Provide a clear, unexpired copy of a government-issued ID (driver's licence, passport or provincial ID). Make sure your name matches the application.

2

INCOME

Share recent pay stubs (usually 2–3), an employment letter, contract or offer letter. If you're self-employed, provide recent bank statements and/or a Notice of Assessment.

3

REFERENCES

Include previous landlord and/or employer references with current contact information (name, phone number and email). Let your references know you're applying so they can respond promptly.

4

CREDIT

A credit report may be requested. You can provide your own recent report (e.g. from Equifax or TransUnion) to help speed up the process.

5

RENTER PROFILE

Tell us who will live there, your preferred move-in date, work/school situation, pets (type, breed and number), and what you are looking for (lease term, amenities, etc.).

AT THE VIEWING

- Listen for noise from neighbours, streets, elevators and mechanical rooms at different times if possible.
- Check water pressure, test appliances and laundry, and look for any signs of leaks.
- Confirm parking availability, storage space, bike room and visitor parking.
- Check your cell reception, natural light and how much heat the unit gets (morning vs. afternoon).
- Ask about building security, common areas (gym, lounge, mail, etc.) and move-in procedures.
- Confirm exactly which utilities are included (e.g. heat, hot water, electricity, internet) and how the rest are billed.
- Ask about any move-in fee, elevator deposit or strata scheduling requirements.

SCAM + PAYMENT CHECK

Verify the property and the person you are dealing with before sending money. Be cautious with unusual payment methods (e.g. wire transfers, gift cards or cryptocurrency) or pressure to pay before a viewing. Read the tenancy agreement carefully before sending any funds and make sure it matches the property, terms and the party you're dealing with.

WHAT STRENGTHENS AN APPLICATION

- Provide complete information and all required documents.
- Respond promptly to requests and be easy to reach.
- Be honest about pets, occupants and your situation.
- Keep documents and payments traceable (e.g. email confirmations and receipts).

GOOD APPLICATION HABITS

Apply promptly, keep your information accurate and up to date, and make sure all documents are clear and readable. Keep copies of your application, documents and receipts in one place, and respond quickly if we request any follow-up information.

Know the lease before the keys

A few careful steps now can prevent very expensive misunderstandings later.

2026 B.C. TENANCY ESSENTIALS



Security deposit

Maximum: one-half of one month's rent.



Pet damage deposit

If applicable, maximum: one-half of one month's rent.



Rent increases

2026 standard annual limit: 2.3%. Notice and timing rules still apply.



Condition inspection

Complete a move-in inspection, document the existing condition and keep a copy of the report.



Written agreement

Confirm rent, term, utilities, parking, pets, occupants and special terms in writing.

BEFORE YOU SIGN



What utilities are included?

Confirm what's included (e.g. heat, hot water, electricity, internet) and what you'll need to set up.



What are the parking / storage details?

Ask about availability, cost, location and any additional agreements.



Is it a fixed-term or month-to-month tenancy?

Understand the start date, end date (if fixed-term) and how renewals work.



What are the occupancy and guest rules?

Confirm the number of occupants allowed and any guest policies.



What are the pet and smoking rules?

Check if pets are allowed, any restrictions, and whether smoking or vaping is permitted.



Are there move-in booking or fee requirements?

Some buildings require elevator bookings, deposits or move-in fees.



Are there strata bylaws that affect daily living?

Ask for a copy of the strata bylaws and be aware of rules on noise, amenities and common areas.

PROTECT YOURSELF AFTER MOVE-IN



Photograph every room

Take clear photos (and video if possible) of every room and any existing damage.



Save important documents

Keep a copy of your signed lease and the move-in inspection report.



Arrange tenant insurance

Protect your personal belongings. Landlord insurance does not cover your items.



Report issues in writing

Let your landlord or property manager know about repairs or issues as soon as possible, in writing.



Ask before making alterations

Get written permission before painting, mounting items or making any changes to the unit.



Keep payment records

Save rent receipts and any related communications in one folder (email or digital).

NEED HELP WITH YOUR RENTAL SEARCH?

I help renters narrow down areas, understand listings, organize applications and navigate the rental process throughout Greater Vancouver.

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2026 reference points

B.C. Residential Tenancy Branch: deposits, rent increases and condition inspections. BC Hydro: residential rates and average apartment electricity use. General information only, not legal advice; confirm current rules at gov.bc.ca/landlordtenant.